

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Helical _____ widely understood to confer stability and efficiency in the locomotion of a variety of microscopic organisms—including bacteria, eukaryotic algae, and ciliates—bestows similar advantages, albeit via different propulsive modes, to larger oceanic macroplanktons, such as salps.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. swimming, is
- B. swimming is
- C. swimming has been
- D. swimming,

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The comma after “swimming” pairs with the dash after “ciliates” to offset the supplementary element (“widely...ciliates”) that interrupts the main clause of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect. Adding the verb “is” here creates an ungrammatical sentence structure with two main verbs (“is” and “bestows”) without appropriate punctuation and/or conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it fails to offset the supplementary element with appropriate punctuation. Furthermore, adding the verb “is” here creates an ungrammatical sentence that has two finite verbs (“is” and “bestows”) without appropriate punctuation and/or conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it fails to offset the supplementary element with appropriate punctuation. Furthermore, adding the verb “has been” here creates an ungrammatical sentence that has two finite verbs (“has been” and “bestows”) without appropriate punctuation and/or conjunction.